

In search of that warm, fuzzy feeling...



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"How ironic is it that when technology exposure was in its infancy, largely trivial when compared to non-digital ways of doing things, it gave me some of my most memorable moments of my life. And now, when we know how critical, life-changing technology is in our collective consciousness, we don't appreciate it as much as we perhaps used to."

Having to partake in an unscheduled house cleaning activity on a particularly lazy weekend, as part of our endeavor to baby-proof the house in the best possible manner, I chanced upon a long forgotten memory. As I was busy inspecting stuff kept in our mezzanine, to discard the unnecessary items so that more floor-level items could be stockpiled there, I chanced upon a ragged box bound in a plastic wrapper. I instinctively knew what it held without having touched the thing for a good 5-6 years. I had almost forgotten about it. Almost.

I brought down the box with great reverence, the box that held my first arcade gaming console -- Sega Mega Drive II. Sixteen bits of pure gaming wonder that a prepubescent me found amazingly fascinating. I still remember the night, all those years ago, when my father brought home the device (after many months of pestering, of course), and I was in heaven. I don't remember doing anything else for the remainder of the night but play the adventures of Sonic the Hedgehog and an early version of Codemaster's Brian Lara Cricket. I even remember neatly putting the console, its controller, and two cartridges back into its original packaging, and sleeping with it wrapped in my arms. What if somebody stole it, I remember telling my much-amused parents? I wasn't going to take that chance. No sir.

That beautiful black box remains but the days of playing on the Sega Mega Drive II have long gone. A digital relic, its original controller has stopped working optimally, and I have a sneaking suspicion that one of my cousins had a big role to play behind my missing Brian Lara cartridge. All of that still can't mar all the great times I remember having with the Mega Drive II, and admittedly I'd be hard-pressed to rekindle that warm, fuzzy feeling in my brain once again.

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collective consciousness, we don't appreciate it as much as we perhaps used to. I got a big kick out of owning my very first cellular phone, but it wasn't the same. And recently, I felt like a kid all over again when I got my first real experience of a 3D printer -- it still wasn't enough to knock the Sega Mega Drive II off its pedestal of my favourite technology-related memory. I've tried but so far failed as an adult to recreate those early emotions, but the quest continues. Maybe I've just been too desensitized to technology, but I remain hopeful.

Digital natives have even lesser appreciation of technology, I feel, simply because they were born in the digital age. This is expected simply because they take for granted a certain way of doing things (through technology) in this world that us '80s-90s kids saw forming and take shape in front of our eyes. I wonder what will blow their minds away, and as my daughter grows up I often think about the type of (digital) memories she'll cherish for the rest of her life, like her father remembers his time with a primitive tech gaming console that left a lasting impression. Ah, the possibilities!

Speaking for myself, unless I sit in a self-driving car or am served a hot beverage by a robot butler I don't think the neurons in my hippocampus will be fired up enough for me to experience the exact same feeling as the one I remember with my first encounter with the Sega Mega Drive II. That's just my best guess, not a certainty, of course.

And that brings me to this question: Which is your most cherished tech-related memory? I would love to hear your story. Write to me at jayesh.shinde@digit.in 